We have no misconceptions about Brandt, about West German social democracy. Illusions are out of place and must not even be allowed. Neither Brandt nor Strauss will introduce socialism in West Germany. There is no process of rapprochement between the GDR and the FRG, it cannot and must not happen. That's what Brandt wants, that's what Strauss wants, that's what the West German bourgeoisie wants. What is important for us is the strengthening of the position of the GDR, its further positive political and economic development, an improvement in the living conditions of the working class, the peasants, the population of the GDR. It is on this task that we must continue to concentrate. So, concentrate everything on consolidating the socialist GDR. Brandt's goals for the GDR are different from ours.

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On the morning of 21 August, Brezhnev and Ulbricht held a private four-hour conversation in which the Russian ignored the First Secretary's request to have his opponent thrown out of the Politburo. The pain was sharpened when Ulbricht was also warned against spreading malicious gossip about Honecker.23

Honecker's ebullience in Moscow, once it subsided, led to a long period of waiting. As the weeks slipped by, routine duties took him to Dresden to 'strengthen the ideological work' of the local party on 15 September and, on 8 October, he joined Ulbricht on the eve of the twenty-first anniversary of the GDR to bestow awards on collectives. The following week in Cottbus, he opened the 'Waffenbrüderschaft' exercises, the largest ever joint Warsaw Pact manoeuvres on GDR territory. Addressing the party faithful, he said the drills would 'prove convincingly that the socialist